

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1428

By Alexander

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate Robert "Bob" Batson upon the occasion of his retirement.

WHEREAS, Robert "Bob" Batson was born on November 7, 1959, and from the earliest chapters of his life, he has demonstrated a calling toward service, compassion, and the solemn care of others during their most difficult hours; and

WHEREAS, Bob Batson pursued his education at Jefferson State Community College, earning an Associate of Applied Science degree in Mortuary Science, a foundation upon which he would build more than four decades of extraordinary service to the people of Tennessee and the nation; and

WHEREAS, after ten years as a licensed funeral director and embalmer, including service as the contract funeral establishment for fatalities at the Fort Campbell, Kentucky, military base, Bob Batson transitioned into executive leadership, serving as executive director of the Tennessee Funeral Directors Association (TFDA) from September 1991 to the present, a tenure spanning thirty-five years of steadfast dedication to the funeral service profession; and

WHEREAS, in his role as executive director, Mr. Batson managed a multifaceted professional association; he represented the best interests of funeral service professionals before the General Assembly, educated State legislators on professional legislation, oversaw association finances, coordinated the annual tradeshow, managed staff, and directed the association's for-profit subsidiary, Tennessee Funeral Securities, Inc.; and

WHEREAS, Bob Batson's expertise and commitment to public safety led him to serve as a Mass Fatalities Management Instructor for the Tennessee Emergency Management Agency; he is also a Certified EMI Train-the-Trainer Instructor, providing specialized training across the State to handle large-scale recovery efforts; and

WHEREAS, since joining the Disaster Mortuary Operational Response Teams (DMORT) in 1993, Bob Batson has served on the front lines of our nation's most profound tragedies, answering the call without hesitation at moments when few others could; and

WHEREAS, after September 11, 2001, Mr. Batson deployed to New York, New York, as a DMORT Family Assistance Section Leader, serving three tours; he initially coordinated information for families of passengers and crew aboard American Flight 11 and United Flight 175 and later assisted with the identification of victims from the World Trade Center; and

WHEREAS, Bob Batson subsequently served as a DMORT Family Assistance Section Leader in Queens, New York, assisting the New York City Medical Examiner following the crash of American Airlines Flight 587, and as Family Assistance Section Leader on the Mississippi Gulf Coast following Hurricane Katrina, helping establish family assistance centers for communities devastated by that catastrophic storm; and

WHEREAS, Bob Batson served as DMORT Morgue Operations Section Leader on the Louisiana Gulf Coast following both Hurricane Katrina and Hurricane Rita, assisting the New Orleans Medical Examiner; and

WHEREAS, Bob Batson was deployed to Haiti following the devastating 2010 earthquake, serving as Morgue Operations Section Leader for the repatriation of American victims and to Puerto Rico following Hurricanes Irma and Maria in the same capacity; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Batson has volunteered his expertise as chairman of the National Council of Funeral Executives and currently serves as chairman of the Tennessee Council of Medical Examiners, having been a board member since 2017, shaping policy and standards that protect the public and honor the deceased; and

WHEREAS, through Bob Batson's commitment to professional development in the funeral industry, he has been actively involved in continuing education requirements for funeral

directors and embalmer licensees, including helping to pass the first-of-its-kind continuing education in Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, Bob Batson has been a stalwart and influential member of his profession; Tennessee has led the nation by electing multiple presidents to the National Funeral Directors Association, including a consecutive presidency for two Tennesseans; and

WHEREAS, beyond the weight of his professional accomplishments, Bob Batson is, at his core, a devoted family man; he shares his life with his wife of forty-five years, Ruby; their two sons, J.T. and Adam; their daughters-in-law; and four beloved granddaughters, who have been his greatest source of joy; and

WHEREAS, he is a skilled craftsman, carpenter, electrician, handyman, painter, guitar player, talented left-handed golfer, dog trainer, soccer official, and kindhearted person who will have numerous projects to complete in his retirement years; and

WHEREAS, Bob Batson exemplifies the finest tradition of Tennessee public service—steady, selfless, and defined by a profound sense of duty to those he serves; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and congratulate Robert "Bob" Batson upon the occasion of his retirement, extending to him our deep appreciation for thirty-five years of leadership at the Tennessee Funeral Directors Association and a lifetime of service to families in their most profound moments of grief and loss.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.